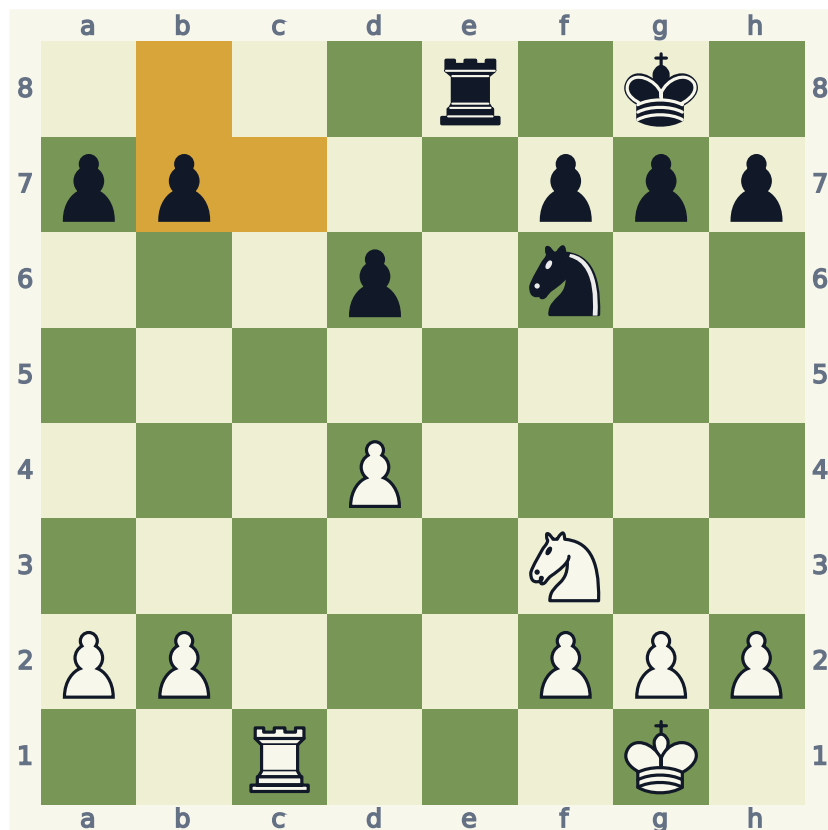


Rooks on the seventh rank

Penetration is valuable when it creates real threats.

A rook on the seventh rank can attack pawns from the side, restrict the enemy king and cooperate with another rook. The rank itself does not guarantee an advantage. Count accessible targets, checks against your own king and the opponent's ability to exchange or trap the invading rook.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- Rc7 attacks b7 along the rank.
- Black can defend the target with ...Rb8.
- The black king cannot cross the seventh rank where the rook's line is clear.

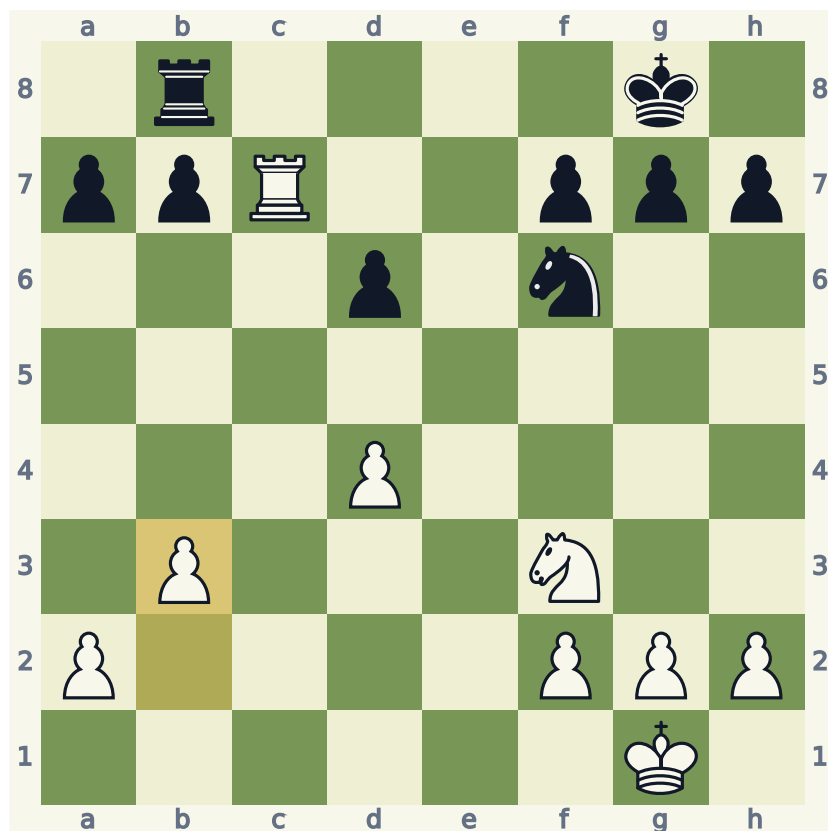
REMEMBER

- Count real targets, not nearby pawns.
- Use the tied defender to improve another piece.
- Check the escape route of the invading rook.

Follow the logic

1. Rc7 Rb8 2. b3

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Rc7

Invalidate with a target. The rook attacks b7, while the pawns on f7 and g7 shield each other from a distant horizontal attack.

...Rb8

Black defends b7. One weakness can often be held, so White needs another useful improvement.

b3

White gives b2 a safer square and prepares to improve the king or knight. The invading rook can tie Black down while other pieces work.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black should seek rook activity, exchanges or checks. Passive defense of b7 may be necessary temporarily, but a counterattack against d4 can reduce the pressure.

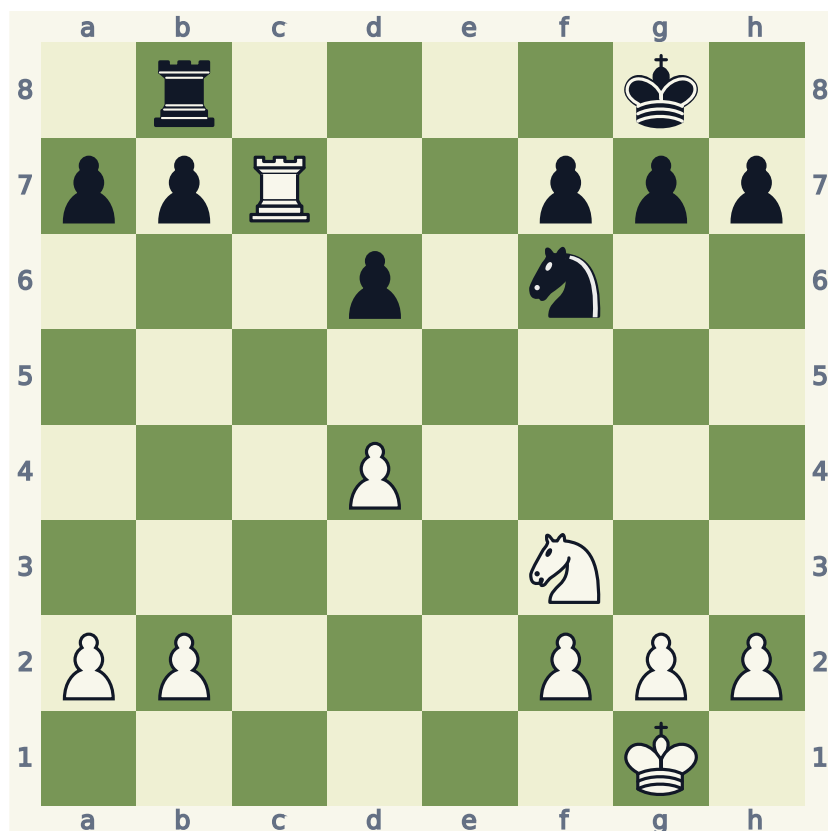
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

A rook cannot attack through an enemy pawn to every pawn behind it. Count the first obstruction in each direction. Do not sacrifice king safety merely to occupy the seventh rank.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



1. Which black pawn is being attacked and defended?
2. What does ...Ne4 tell you about Black's counterplay?
3. Should White assume that Rxb7 wins a free pawn?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

What if a second white rook joined the seventh rank safely?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 1r4k1/ppR2ppp/3p1n2/8/3P4/5N2/PP3PPP/6K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. The white rook attacks b7 and Rb8 defends it. The invasion ties the black rook to a task, but it has not yet won anything.
2. The knight can become active in the center, attacking f2, d2, c3, c5, d6, f6, g3 and g5. White must compare this activity with its own pressure instead of assuming that the tied rook makes Black helpless.
3. No. Rxb7 allows ...Rxb7, exchanging a rook for a pawn unless White has a further concrete tactic. Pressure on a defended pawn and a winning capture are different claims.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. b3 Ne4

Changed feature: Two rooks can create lateral threats and mating nets, but the move order still matters. Check whether Black can force an exchange or give perpetual checks before doubling.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Play five moves from the exercise position. Keep Rc7 active while improving the king or knight; then switch sides and search for checks and central activity.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 11, 18, 22. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.